



SIGNET
EDUCATION

SIGNET'S GUIDE TO EXTRACURRICULARS:

*Choosing and pursuing meaningful
activities outside the classroom.*

INTRODUCTION

Extracurricular activities are one of the best parts of the high school experience. Not only are they a fantastic way for students to deepen their knowledge, develop new skills, and form communities around common interests, they are also fun!

(And yes, as you probably know, college admissions officers like extracurriculars, too.)

Here at Signet, we believe in supporting the growth of the student as a whole person. Extracurriculars play a vital role in helping students flourish. Learning how to pursue extracurriculars the right way sets students on a course of exploration, curiosity, and engagement. It makes them better citizens and better leaders, and puts them on a trajectory toward a life well lived, full of purpose, passion, and excitement.

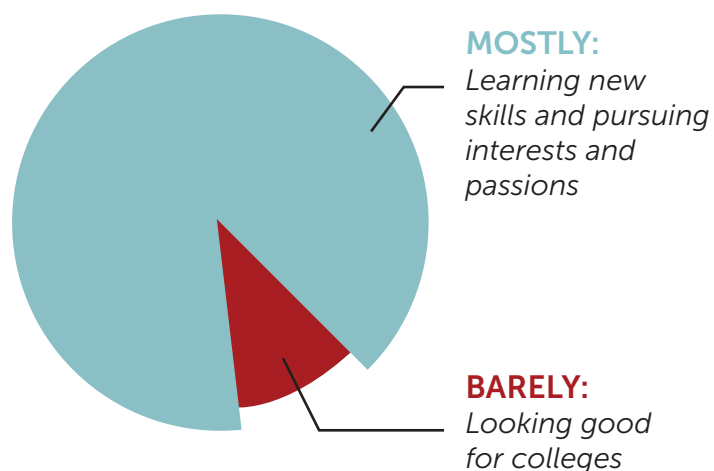
In this guide, we'll tell you how students can pursue extracurriculars in an authentic way that will help them grow—and also help them apply to college.

Before we go any further, it's vital that you understand this point: extracurricular activities are about so much more than getting into college.

Developing interests outside of school creates individuals who know how to build meaningful life experiences for themselves.

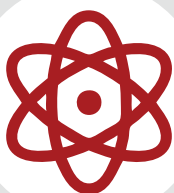
If you're still in the camp of *"Sounds nice, but I just want to know which activities will help get into an Ivy League..."* repeat after us: **The main purpose of extracurriculars is to help students develop the skills to build a meaningful life (and to have fun!).** Rinse and repeat until it starts to sound like the truth!

To say it another way, extracurriculars are:



DEFINING EXTRACURRICULARS

Extracurriculars are non-classroom, non-credit activities. They are structured ways that students spend their time outside the classroom.



What Specific Benefits Can High School Students Get From Extracurriculars?

- ☑ **Real-life Skills.** Managing a team, setting and sticking to a budget, and seeing a project through to completion are valuable experiences that prepare students for life after college.
- ☑ **Problem-Solving.** While students may learn how to problem-solve in their classrooms, independently solving problems that arise during a meaningful pursuit takes this ability to a completely new level.
- ☑ **Work Ethic.** Not all students click with school, and thus not all students will be motivated to improve their work ethic and stick-to-it-ness in the classroom. There's nothing like an extracurricular project you're passionate about to teach you the value of hard work.
- ☑ **Positive Impact.** Make a difference by using service-oriented activities to benefit others in the community.
- ☑ **Community.** Find support and friendship by joining a group of like-minded people with the same interests or goals, or by engaging with the local community.
- ☑ **Leadership Abilities.** Mentoring a younger student, captaining an athletic team, or holding an office for a club instill a sense of responsibility and professionalism.
- ☑ **Opportunities for Career Exploration.** Extracurriculars can help students determine their vocational path in college and beyond.
- ☑ **New Ways of Learning.** Learn in environments outside the traditional classroom model.

EXTRACURRICULARS AND THE COLLEGE ADMISSIONS PROCESS:

You may have noticed that the previous list of benefits didn't include "Impress the heck out of admissions officers to get into an awesome college!" That's because only about 10% of the reason for pursuing extracurriculars has to do with the college process. The other 90% is to help students develop into engaged adults living meaningful lives. (Remember this idea from a couple pages ago? It's still true!)

However, colleges do look at students' extracurriculars, so let's take a moment to talk about the role these activities play in college admissions.

Extracurriculars are one of several pieces that represent a student on their college application. Other pieces include GPA, letters of recommendation, standardized test scores, difficulty of coursework, the personal statement, and potentially an interview. Extracurriculars often differentiate students from one another, especially at highly selective colleges.

But aside from identifying exceptional students among a sea of candidates, why do colleges care about extracurriculars in the first place?

First of all, colleges want highly engaged students on their campuses. Past behavior (i.e. extracurriculars in high school) is the best indicator of future behavior (i.e. being an active member of the student body in college).

Second, extracurricular activities demonstrate a student's capabilities in areas such as time management, teamwork, responsibility, leadership, and discipline. These skills won't show up in a GPA, but they tell the college a lot about what kind of person a student is, and help them determine whether the student is a good fit for their campus.

Finally, extracurriculars show that a student has interests and a life outside of the classroom. While colleges want to admit good students, they also want to admit people who will be able to put their education and learning to use in a broader context than the school environment.

AUTHENTIC ENGAGEMENT VS. APPLICATION PADDING

All that said, *more* extracurriculars does not necessarily mean *better*. Colleges do not want students to pad their applications! Admissions officers can tell the difference between a student who is genuinely interested in their extracurriculars and one who's trying to pad their resume. Students shouldn't worry about impressing admissions

officers with the sheer number of their activities. **What impresses admissions officers most is students who have had a high school experience that's meaningful and true to who they are**, which is very different from joining the maximum number of clubs possible.

THE ACTIVITY LIST

The primary way that colleges learn about a student's extracurriculars is through the Activity List. This is part of the Common Application, and a quick glance at it illuminates exactly what we have been talking about: this is a chance for students to illustrate a deeper level of engagement with the activities they care about most.

The Activity List doesn't have a ton of space, which says something about its purpose. It's not intended to be a laundry list of activities because admissions

officers aren't concerned with how many extracurriculars students are involved in. Rather, they care about the curiosity, interest, and passion that sparks their involvement—which are the things students should care about, too.

The Activity List on the Common Application appears below. Unless there are extraordinary circumstances, we recommend students refine their activities list so it fits in the space provided.

The Common App has space to list 10 activities.

If you absolutely need to share more, there is an **"Additional Information"** section that allows up to 650 words to highlight an applicant's background and experiences, which may include extracurriculars.

There are also options for sending in an Arts Supplement or additional research for particularly involved projects or activities.

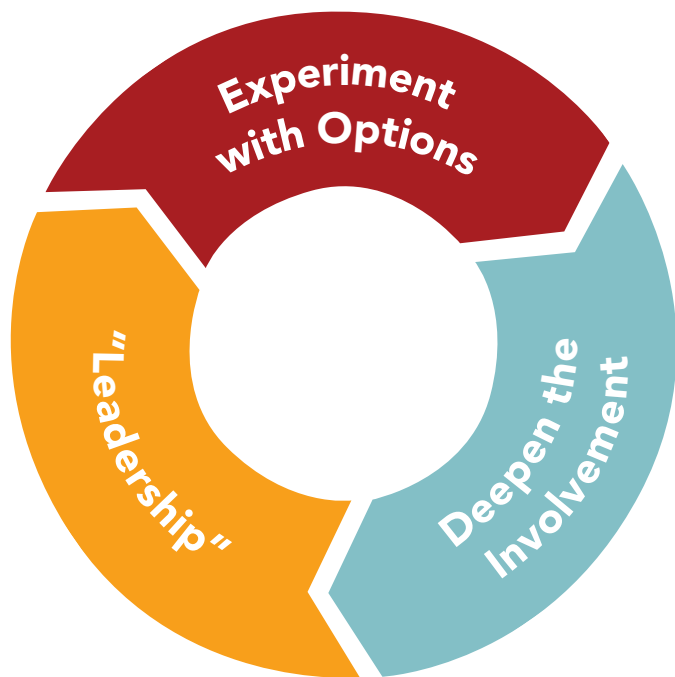
The Common Application	
Activities	
Athletics: JV/Varsity	
9, 10, 11, 12 Year 15 hr/wk, 52 wk/yr Continue	Swim, Member of Varsity Swim Team. Varsity since 10th; established and oversaw weightlifting program that improved team times by an average of 10 seconds.
Athletics: Club	
9, 10, 11 Year 8 hr/wk, 40 wk/yr Continue	Water polo, Founder & captain: water polo. Founded club water polo team. Lead practice on weekends and organize monthly scrimmages.
Family Responsibilities	
9, 10, 11, 12 Year 10 hr/wk, 52 wk/yr	Babysitter. Care for younger siblings in the evenings when parents are working, including cooking dinner and helping them with their homework.
Journalism/Publication	
11, 12 Year 5 hr/wk, 52 wk/yr Continue	Founder of fitness blog "Sweat Stain." Created blog reviewing athletic wear/fitness and workout routines. Post weekly and have generated 1,000 subscribers.
School Spirit	
9, 10, 11, 12 School 2 hr/wk, 30 wk/yr	Class representative. Chair of Jr Prom Committee. Participate in weekly meetings to plan social events and fundraisers. Led planning for Junior Prom and Relay for Life.
Community Service (Volunteer)	
11, 12 School 1 hr/wk, 20 wk/yr Continue	Tutor & role model. Run 1-hour after school homework group for five 3rd graders, focusing on math, science, and social skills.
Work (Paid)	
11 Break 10 hr/wk, 4 wk/yr Continue	Lab tech at Polytech U. Intern in cancer research lab. Assisted grad students with experiments and learned how a lab functions.
Athletics: JV/Varsity	
9 School 8 hr/wk, 10 wk/yr	Track and field, Member of track team. Ran 100m dash and 800m relay. Was unable to continue in 10th grade due to Water Polo commitments.

To view an example of the "good" vs. "not so good" versions of the activity list, please refer to **Appendix C**. For more details on the **Common App Activity List**, check out our guide at www.signeteducation.com/guides.

PURSUING EXTRACURRICULARS

Now that we've gotten the college application part out of the way, let's explore how to actually engage in meaningful activities. At Signet, we love a good three-step process, so we've broken down our approach into the following method:

The Process for Pursuing Extracurriculars



1. Experiment with Options

The first phase of the Extracurriculars Process is all about exploration. For many parents, this is the most difficult phase because it feels like "wasting time." However, the difference between wasting time and pursuing a meaningful activity is in the approach.

Students in this phase should have plenty of freedom to pursue activities that sound interesting to them. These activities don't need to be structured at this point. It's more about testing the waters to see what feels like a good fit. Students looking for activities can visit **Appendix A** of this guide for **101 Ideas for Extracurriculars**.

During this period, both students and parents should keep the following pieces of advice in mind:

Students: Spend time staring at the clouds.

This tip comes from Cal Newport, one of our favorite authors, who writes about how students can become successful at performing productive, meaningful, and valuable work.

Newport believes students should spend less time in structured activities and more time exposing themselves to interesting things and ideas. When a flicker of interest sparks into a flame, students will have plenty of free space in their schedules to pursue their new passion.

Parents: Don't overwhelm students with options.

While we strongly advocate exploring a broad range of extracurricular activities, students won't benefit from having so many activities that they feel overwhelmed. If you're using extracurriculars to start building a meaningful life, as we recommend, what's the rush? Students are continually learning from this whole process, even in the times when growth might seem a little slow.

A student who is spread too thin is more likely to be stressed out and, as a result, the experience of their extracurriculars may start to feel like an obligation rather than what it should be: an opportunity to pursue their interests, passions, and have fun!

Instead of trying to fit a ton of activities into a semester, students should choose just a few extracurriculars to explore. They can stick with what feels really exciting, leave behind what doesn't, and make plenty of space to check out something new.

Use electives wisely.

While extracurriculars are, by definition, activities that are not pursued for academic credit, students should feel free to use any available electives to explore areas of interest. (Think art, music, theater, weightlifting, archaeology, shop, computer science, etc.). Students who really click with the material in class can go on to pursue that topic as an extracurricular. This approach gives students a feel for the activity while preserving their precious free time outside of school hours.

Write it down.

It can be helpful for students to keep a journal or notes while exploring different activities, to record their thoughts and feelings on what they are drawn to. Then as they move to the next phase of the process, they'll have a clearer picture of what activities they should focus on more intentionally.

2. Deepen the Involvement

Existing Groups, Teams, or Clubs.

Once students have identified a few areas of interest, a natural next step is to deepen their involvement. This can look quite different depending on the activity, so we've broken this step down into two options.

Let's look at Angela, a student who wants to start focusing on her school's math team. Angela could deepen her involvement by:

- Consistently showing up for team meetings.
- Signing up for math meets.
- Joining the committee that plans team events.
- Volunteering for the tutoring program run by the team.

Forging Your Own Path.

For students whose interests fall outside the bounds of traditional school organizations, there are myriad ways to meaningfully engage with the activities they love.

Non-traditional routes may offer students more creativity, freedom, and independence than conventional ones, and colleges are often eager to embrace those who take this alternative approach to extracurriculars. Keep in mind that when students are conveying their extracurricular participation to colleges, they need to ensure that even non-traditional activities have a defined structure and are measurable in some way.

Let's take an example many of our parents will appreciate. Taylor loves video games but needs to figure out how to turn his passion into a meaningful extracurricular. Taylor could deepen his involvement by:

- Starting a video game club at school.
- Writing game reviews for an online site.

- Designing his own video game and sharing it with the world.
- Organizing a community game-a-thon for charity.

Other examples of non-traditional extracurriculars include starting a fashion blog, building a robot and sharing the code as open source, or writing and self-publishing a novel over the summer.

Whether students are taking a traditional or alternative approach to extracurriculars, deepening their involvement is a key component to giving these activities impact and making them part of a meaningful life.

A Side Note on Hobbies vs. Extracurriculars

Students who are forging their own paths should be mindful of the difference between extracurriculars and hobbies.

Hobbies are personal, and very often they're done purely for pleasure or relaxation. While we very much support them, hobbies may not actually lead to all the benefits we described above (exposure, exploration, leadership, problem-solving, community, etc...).

What can turn a hobby into an extracurricular activity? Usually it's structure and commitment.

For example, reading avidly is a **hobby**. Using your passion for reading to start a book club at the local library is an **extracurricular activity**.

Hobbies are an excellent starting point for developing students' passions, but keep in mind that **extracurricular activities should have a clear structure and some way to measure impact, either on oneself or on the community.**

In other words, extracurriculars are a little higher stakes, requiring students to make a commitment to themselves or others.

3. “Leadership”

“Leadership.” We have it in quotes for a reason. Most people think of leadership as a fancy title, public speeches, and impressive feats of management. But leadership is a lot more than that: it’s about being so committed to something that you develop a deep personal feeling of ownership.

Leadership means going the extra mile to get something done right. It means finding others who will support you in your cause and projects. Perhaps most importantly, leadership means creating and owning your vision for what you’re doing and where you’re going.

Leadership doesn’t have to be public or grand. It might be quiet and behind the scenes. Students will know they’re leading when they stop waiting for tasks to be given to them and start acting based on their own internal vision.

Whereas involvement (the second stage in our Extracurriculars Process, just after experimentation) happens when a student finds ways to be involved more consistently in an activity, leadership happens when they make that activity their own.

Just as students can choose traditional roles or forge their own path when it comes to deepening their involvement in extracurriculars, they also have the freedom to pursue conventional or alternative ways of stepping into leadership roles.

Traditional Leadership.

Traditional leadership looks familiar to us. Class President. Captain of the basketball team. What’s great about traditional leadership is that it comes with a clear set of preconceived notions about what’s involved, both for students who take up these roles and for admissions officers reviewing them on the activities list. We instinctively know that the class president was probably responsible for working with administrators and planning large events like Senior Prom, while the captain of the basketball team, in addition to displaying athletic excellence, acted as a model for sportsmanlike conduct and boosted the team’s morale.

Alternative Leadership.

Students may prefer to embrace broader definitions

of what leadership can look like. Embodying unconventional, outside-the-box leadership opportunities is often the perfect fit for students who don’t naturally align with traditional leadership structures.

Here are some examples of alternative leadership:

- Pursuing an independent project on nights and weekends that you can then share with the world.
- Getting fellow members of the swim team together at a local pool to swim laps during the off-season.
- Helping your family, supporting your siblings, or taking care of an aging grandparent.
- Organizing around a cause you’re passionate about.
- Being so interested in a particular culture that you learn the language independently to more thoroughly explore its history.
- Mapping out a long road trip for you and three friends that’s based on an interest you share.
- Organizing a speaker series at your school around a topic you feel everyone needs to know more about.

Sharing a list like this is slightly risky, as some students might be tempted to copy or imitate some of these activities as a “shortcut” to leadership. But that’s not how it works! Leadership, as the third phase in our cycle, should be an organic outgrowth of a genuine interest and engagement in an activity. ***Everyone’s leadership will look different!***

While parents and students sometimes believe that students need to hold certain leadership titles in order to appeal to college admissions officers, this is simply not true. Colleges are usually very open-minded when it comes to the notion of leadership. Admissions offices recognize that there are various ways that leadership can grow and take shape, and value students on both traditional and alternative paths. When looking for leadership opportunities, students should not worry about titles or accomplishments. Rather, focus on the concepts of initiative (taking matters into their own hands) and engagement (being invested in their own causes). These qualities foster long-term growth and development, and encompass a broader definition of what it means to be a leader.

THE EXTRACURRICULARS TIMELINE

Now that we've gone through the Extracurriculars Process, let's take a look at how that might map onto the high school years. This is an arc that many of our students have followed with success, which we define as, most importantly, having a meaningful experience and, secondarily, being well received by college admissions officers.

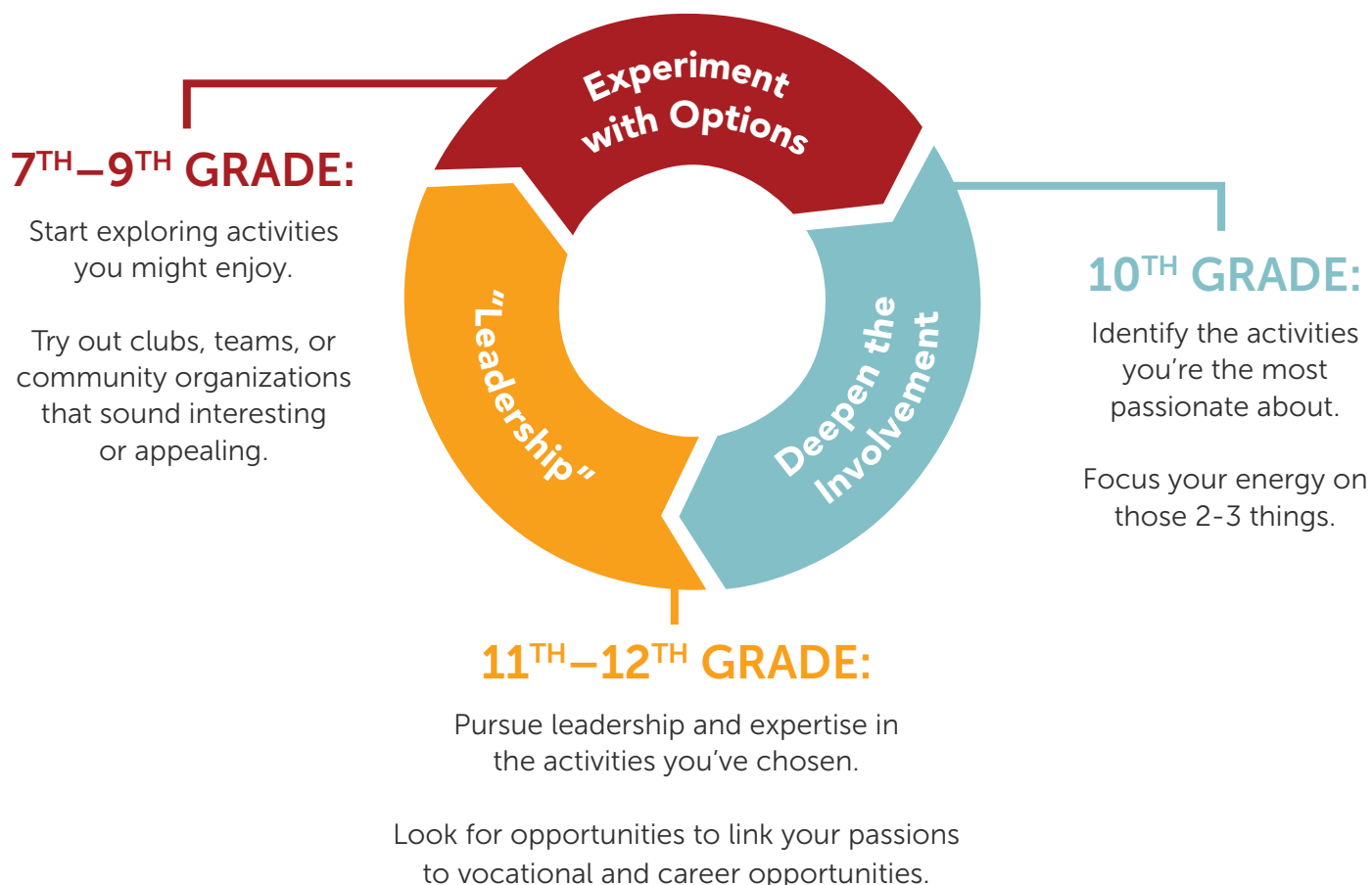
As a disclaimer, the timeline we've suggested below is our general recommendation, but there is always room for variation and there will always be exceptions.

This timeline is also helpful in terms of setting students up for college. They'll develop a unique set of skills and interests as a result of pursuing the Extracurricular Process to its end. And because of this, college admissions offices will find them to be attractive candidates. By the time the

student is preparing applications, they will be deeply involved in a few activities of real interest, and pursuing leadership in those activities as well.

Here's a second disclaimer before you view the timeline: Pursuing extracurriculars is truly an organic process. Students might repeat the process multiple times without finding what they're passionate about. It's okay if students do not complete the process before finishing high school.

Remember that the main reason for pursuing extracurriculars isn't about college anyway (*are you sick of us repeating ourselves yet?*). **So whether or not this timeline neatly lines up with the four years of high school or not, students should still engage in this process** so they can—you guessed it—learn skills for building meaningful lives.



CONSIDERATIONS

Should I stay or should I go?

What happens if a student loses “that loving feeling” about an extracurricular activity? Should they stick with their commitments through senior year, or is it okay to walk away? Many students are afraid of the repercussions that quitting an extracurricular might have on their college admissions.

We’d like to offer the following thoughts:

- If a student’s physical or mental health or academic performance is in jeopardy, students and parents should have a conversation about quitting sooner rather than later.
- If a student is already committed to a set amount of time (such as a sports season) or a particular event (like a concert), they should do their best to follow through on those obligations. That shows dedication and integrity, especially to others who may be depending on them.
- If a student is only sticking with the activity for the college admissions offices, that’s not a good enough reason. Students: It’s always the right choice to present your authentic self to colleges, even if that authentic self just decided they’d rather breakdance than play chess.

Remember, pursuing extracurriculars is about learning the skill of engaging and exploring for life after high school. In life, commitment and dedication are good, but so is knowing when it’s

time to move on. Students need to practice this skill as well. While you don’t want to put your head in the sand when it comes to thinking about extracurriculars vis-à-vis the college process, you should certainly pursue your own path, and let that path be how you represent yourself to admissions officers.

When a student is thinking about quitting an activity, they should make some time for reflection and try to get to the root cause of their distress.

Essentially, if a student wants to quit an activity just because it’s hard, that may not be a good enough reason. We all face challenges and have to deal with discomfort in our lives. Very often, our greatest challenges are also our greatest learning opportunities.

On the other hand, if an activity is truly not a good fit, or if the stress or anxiety associated with it is having a serious effect on the student, quitting may be the right choice. Making this determination requires a good amount of reflection and honesty on the part of the student. **Appendix B** of this guide contains a list of questions students can ask themselves if they find themselves thinking about quitting, and can help walk them through the reflection process.

Let’s look at a couple of examples of students deciding whether to stay or go.



MARIA



BOBBY

- Joined mock trial team because he/she loves watching *Law & Order*.
- Assigned the part of lead attorney.
- Did not perform well at the first meeting, and did not have fun.

Should they quit mock trial?

Both Maria & Bobby take time to contemplate their experience.
They ask themselves questions in **Appendix B**.

- What she loves about courtroom dramas *is the acting*.
- She didn't like the aggressive role of lead attorney.
- She loved helping prep the witnesses and exploring their characters.

Should she stay or go?

Maria should STAY.

She should try being a **witness** instead of a lawyer!

- What he loves about courtroom dramas *is the legal issues*.
- He has stage fright and hates speaking in public.
- He loved doing background research on the trial topic.

Should he stay or go?

Bobby should GO.

Maybe he can start a **legal column** for his school newspaper instead!

CASE STUDY: THE STORY OF A REAL STUDENT

One of our favorite extracurricular stories is about a real life Signet student named Ed. Ed started as an artist and ended up an engineer. He always let himself be guided by his interest and a sense of exploration, and his journey unfolded organically as a result.

Ed's story illustrates how students who stay authentic and curious can find themselves on all kinds of adventures, the kind that might lead to one's true calling in life. We'll let Ed tell the rest himself.

"Hi, I'm Ed. I'm here to talk about my extracurricular activities, which are primarily Botball, the robotics team, and Science Olympiad. I am also working on a couple of projects outside of school, including building a fully autonomous robot that uses a navigation algorithm to identify an object, pick it up, and bring it back to me.

Robotics is the common thread in my extracurriculars now, but it didn't start off that way. In middle school I was actually an artsy kid. I mostly worked with paper, making models and doing origami. One day I showed up at an engineering club meeting at my school, and I realized there were lots of other materials I could be using to make stuff. The idea of making something with a practical function really appealed to me.

In the summer after 7th grade I was part of a robotics boot camp, and my design won first place in the competition. That sparked my real interest in robotics.

From there, I started recycling previous art projects and my first robot to build something new. I got more interested in exploring where I could take robotics. After 8th grade I took a free course in programming, which came in handy during high school. My interest in robotics just exploded from there. The programming, the art, the boot camp: it all seemed to line up for me in this one field.

As an artist, I always took the time after making a model or drawing to really admire it, including noticing whatever flaws or mistakes I happened to catch. With robotics I still find myself doing that. I will sit down, boot up a robotic arm, and just let it react according to its programming. It still sparks the same sense of admiration and magic that I first found in art.

Through robotics I've gained a lot more problem-solving skills. I've learned to act on my own initiative, but also to ask for help when I need it. Socially, sharing a common interest has brought a lot of new people into my life. Now I'm going back to my middle school, introducing students to robotics and helping out whenever I can.

To parents, I'd say the best thing you can do is support your kids without pushing them too hard. Allow them to follow their own interests and encourage them when they find something they love. One of the most important ways my parents supported me was by giving me rides, which sounds simple, but meant a lot.

To students, the ultimate advice I'd give would be to try out different things. If I hadn't gone to engineering club and had just stuck with art, I wouldn't have realized there's a whole other field that suits me better. You don't have to convince yourself to like any one activity. Just give it a try. It's fine if nothing sticks at first; eventually you'll find something that really draws you in.

At the same time, don't just give an activity a quick visit and think that you're not fit for it. Make an effort to get engaged and learn about the topic. You can't say something doesn't capture your heart if you didn't first try to put your heart into it. Explore what really interests you. It's more important to make yourself better than to make yourself look good."



FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS:

What if am not passionate about anything?

Every student operates on their own timeline when it comes to this process. If it doesn't feel like you're passionate about anything in particular, maybe you haven't found the right activity yet! Keep exploring and engaging, and remember that being curious is a mindset and a conscious choice. This process will help you build a skill that will serve you for your entire life.

What if I don't find the thing I love until my senior year?

First, congratulate yourself for finding something that lights you up inside! It's never too late to start pursuing your interests, even if you've already sent in your college applications. (Here comes the chorus again: extracurriculars are about so much more than college admissions!) If you do have a chance to share your newfound passion with college admissions officers, tell them the story of how you got there. Chances are good that your willingness to keep exploring and your openness to new ideas played a role, and colleges want to know that about you.

What if I don't have time to explore a lot of different extracurricular activities?

We get that students' time is limited! On the other hand, part of extracurricular involvement is learning time management skills to accommodate for academic life and other activities.

If you're feeling overwhelmed by extracurriculars, start pruning: eliminate the things that don't excite you and focus on fewer activities.

For students who have major other responsibilities, like holding a job or caring for family members, try to reframe the things you're already doing in a different light. Family and work obligations provide many of the same benefits and opportunities for skill-building and leadership that clubs and teams offer, and college admissions offices absolutely see it that way as well!

What if I actually like those traditional extracurricular activities?

Being part of debate club, student government, or team sports is great! As long as you are authentically following your own passions and interests, you've got nothing to worry about. Put your best efforts toward your activities, and when it comes time for college admissions, just remember to frame your activities in terms of what YOU love about them, not what you think colleges want to hear.

What if I'm shy and really don't want to be a leader?

Let us introduce you to the concept of "followership." This means being someone who understands their role in supporting the leaders of the group or organization—in other words, being a team player. The truth is that every activity needs willing and engaged followers; otherwise, the leaders have nobody to lead! It's important to explore outside your comfort zone now and then, but it's also valuable to know the roles that fit you best, and where you provide the most benefit to a group.

Conclusion:

The single idea we most hope to convey with this guide is simple: extracurricular activities are about so much more than college admissions. Rather, these activities present an incredible opportunity to learn the skills associated with building a rich, meaningful life. Students who explore their interests, deepen their involvement, and develop leadership qualities will naturally come to embody the qualities that colleges are looking for in future students.

While there is an ideal timeline that matches up perfectly with the college admissions timeline, **students should always focus first on finding activities that are truly a good fit for them.**

If that means letting go of the timeline, then that's exactly what they should do. The real value of the extracurriculars process lies not in arriving at each step precisely on time, but in helping students discover what engages and excites them most.

APPENDIX A:

101 EXTRACURRICULAR IDEAS

1. Attend a local city-council meeting
2. Join a martial arts group
3. Take a cooking class
4. Cook every recipe out of your favorite cookbook
5. Undergo lifeguard training
6. Offer to babysit for a family friend
7. Volunteer as an English tutor at your local library
8. Find and attend a debate club (*at your school or elsewhere*)
9. Try rock climbing at a gym
10. Build your own rock-climbing wall with friends
11. Get a job (*Bonus points if you try something you might not otherwise do, like work in a restaurant or do city cleanup.*)
12. Grow vegetables in a garden or window box
13. Take an online class in something that isn't offered by your school
14. Start a podcast with a friend
15. Take an online coding course
16. Create a list of "Great Books" you want to read
17. Pick up an instrument you've never tried before
18. Take a dance class: hip hop, ballet, tap, modern, anything!
19. Take a yoga class
20. Put together a donation drive with a local charity: books, winter clothes, canned food, etc.
21. Volunteer at a middle school after-school program
22. Pick a topic you love and want to be an expert in and start researching at your local library
23. Run errands for an elderly neighbor
24. Coach younger students in a sport you love
25. Learn how to bake (*It's like chemistry but you can eat the results!*)
26. Take up hiking
27. Advocate for a cause you believe in by raising awareness at your school
28. Expose yourself to a new style of music
29. Pick 10 people you want to learn about and then read up on them
30. Submit a story to a story slam (*such as the Moth*)
31. Hold your own story or poetry slam
32. Put together a group to do a one-time community service activity in your neighborhood: clean up a park, have a sports day for local kids
33. Contribute to an environmental movement—locally, nationally, or internationally
34. Start a blog about a topic you love
35. Take up photography (*Instagram counts, if you're truly engaged*)
36. Attend local lectures on topics that interest or are new to you
37. Call or write your local legislator about an issue you care about
38. Get involved in a local theater organization (*There's more to theater than acting!*)
39. Landscape design your parents' yard (*Make sure to ask permission first!*)
40. Try bird watching—it's not just for old people
41. Try tai chi—that's not just for old people either!
42. Find a local trail to bike
43. Volunteer at an animal shelter
44. Feed people—Try a soup kitchen or volunteer at Meals on Wheels
45. Help special-needs kids or adults by looking for organizations near you that you can join
46. Learn to freestyle rap
47. Be a healthcare volunteer at a counseling or samaritan agency
48. Learn a particular dance by watching YouTube videos

49. Learn about World War II (*or any other historical topic*)
50. Make the perfect French omelette (*It takes practice!*)
51. Curate content that you care about online via Tumblr, Twitter, Instagram, or Facebook
52. Volunteer as a research assistant with a local professor
53. Trace your family lineage
54. Collect family stories (*Bonus: make a family-focused podcast with conversations with your extended family*)
55. Canvas or phone bank for a local or national politician
56. Start a book club
57. Learn origami
58. Become CPR certified
59. Try to get a poem or short story published
60. Learn how to make beats using your phone, tablet, or laptop
61. Create your own music video to an existing song
62. Learn to compost
63. Learn to build things-start with simple furniture ideas
64. Master something small: the perfect sandwich, a yo-yo trick, etc.
65. Host a game night
66. Learn the basics of robotics with Arduino or Raspberry Pi
67. Watch all the movies on a Top 10 list of your choice
68. Blog/write a review about each movie you watched
69. Start a neighborhood email list or listserv
70. Pick an international issue you want to learn more about
71. Learn a new language (*look at online resources like **Duolingo!***)
72. Host a jam session
73. Do 50 random acts of kindness
74. Create beauty in your community through paintings, murals, or even by just handing out positive messages
75. Raise money for a cause you care about
76. Explore every public space in your city and create a photo blog
77. Teach computer skills to the elderly
78. Foster bee and butterfly habitats (*either yourself or advocate for them*)
79. Read a current events publication like the **New York Times** regularly
80. Help your family reduce its carbon footprint
81. Volunteer in training service dogs
82. Sign up for a club at your school that's outside your comfort zone
83. Send a care package to deployed troops
84. Join a religious youth group
85. Learn about the world's major religious traditions and visit houses of worship in your town
86. Explore the oral history of a community in your area
87. Write a profile about someone influential in your community
88. Try archery
89. Take a fitness class at your local YMCA (*or gym*)
90. Learn to meditate
91. Do a silent retreat
92. Volunteer at a local hospice care center
93. Shadow a professional in a field of interest
94. Take a survival class
95. Make an emergency plan for your family (*e.g. hurricanes, earthquakes, zombie attacks*)
96. Join a robotics club
97. Go to Toastmasters and improve your public speaking
98. Keep a journal
99. Try bodyweight exercises
100. Find and participate in an open mic night
101. Volunteer at a farmer's market

APPENDIX B:

REFLECTION QUESTIONS FOR STUDENTS WHO ARE CONSIDERING QUITTING AN EXTRACURRICULAR

It's important for students to find extracurricular activities that match well with what they are most interested in or passionate about. As a student goes through the process we've laid out in this guide, they may find that a particular activity no longer feels like a good fit.

The decision to quit an extracurricular is deeply personal, and should be well considered. It's not worth staying in an activity just because a student

thinks it will impress college admissions officers. On the other hand, students need to learn how to deal with obstacles and challenges, so it is not necessarily the answer to quit the first time something feels hard.

The following questions will allow students considering quitting an activity to clarify how they are feeling, and help them determine whether quitting is the right choice for them.

Am I giving up because this is hard? Or because this really isn't what I want?

Am I giving up because I don't think what I have done is good enough?

(Fear of failure is real and paralyzing for many high school students!)

What would need to change in order for me not to give up on this?

Is this keeping me from doing something else that is important to me?

What would I rather be doing with this time?

What am I already doing that I like more than this activity?

What am I doing to procrastinate finishing tasks I've assigned myself?

Is there a different way I can be involved in this same interest?

APPENDIX C:

"GOOD" VS. "NOT SO GOOD" VERSIONS OF THE COMMON APP ACTIVITY LIST

Not so good version

Activities

Community Service (Volunteer)

11, 12
School
1 hr/wk, 20 wk/yr
Continue

Tutor.
tutoring math/science for students at HKS

An admissions officer would wonder why a student put this first with such a small time commitment.

Make sure that you explain what any acronyms mean: admissions officers might not be familiar with all the terms you use!

Work (Paid)

11
Break
10 hr/wk, 4 wk/yr
Continue

Lab tech
Histopathology intern studying interleukins

Beware of jargon! This won't make sense to a non-scientist.

Seems strange that this summer activity is 2nd priority.

Student Govt./Politics

9, 10, 11, 12
School
5 hr/wk, 30 wk/yr

Class representative.
I am an elected class representative and participate in weekly meetings.

This sentence takes up too much space and does not communicate anything about this student's role in the organization.

Community Service (Volunteer)

10, 12
Break
2 hr/wk, 1 wk/yr
Continue

Food server
@ homeless shelter for Thanksgiving.

You don't have to list everything you ever did, especially if it's no longer a significant commitment to you!

Athletics: JV/Varsity

9, 10, 11, 12
Year
15 hr/wk, 52 wk/yr
Continue

Swim, Member of Varsity Swim Team.
JV 9th & 10th. Varsity 11th & 12th. Swim 50 free, 100 butterfly, and IM.

This activity is listed as #5, but it is the largest time commitment. What does this say about this student's priorities?

Other Club/Activity

10, 11, 12
Year
8 hr/wk, 40 wk/yr
Continue

Water Polo Player.
I play water polo with my friends at the YMCA on the weekends and after school. Three times per year we have a bracket to play against other water pol

This student ran out of characters and still didn't manage to tell the whole story.

Family Responsibilities

9, 10, 11, 12
Break
10 hr/wk, 52 wk/yr

Babysitter
Watch Tess and Steph after school.

This is a lot of time, and suggests that home life is really important to this student, but the description doesn't really tell a story or show how it impacts their life!

Other Club/Activity

11, 12
School
5 hr/wk, 52 wk/yr
Continue

Blogger.
Write Sweat Stain

This is extremely unclear: with no context, what is an admissions officer supposed to think this means?

Athletics: JV/Varsity

9
Break
8 hr/wk, 10 wk/yr

Track and field, Member of JV track team.
800m relay

This student only did this activity in 9th grade, but the description is very short. More context would help the admissions officer understand why.

Athletics: Club

9, 10, 11, 12
Break
25 hr/wk, 1 wk/yr

Other Sport, Recreational Jet Ski
Jet ski at Uncle Luke's lake house

This really sounds like something that this student did for fun. No need to pad the list to get it up to 10 activities!

25 hours a week is a lot—even for something that's being done for fun on vacation. Make sure you're putting realistic numbers here!

Good version

This is now listed as priority 1, which is reflected in the time commitment. The student added details about the contributions they made to the team, even if they weren't shown through official leadership positions.

Much better category than "Other"!

Activities

Athletics: JV/Varsity

9, 10, 11, 12

Year

15 hr/wk, 52 wk/yr

Continue

Swim, Member of Varsity Swim Team.

Varsity since 10th; established and oversaw weightlifting program that improved team times by an average of 10 seconds.

Athletics: Club

9, 10, 11

Year

8 hr/wk, 40 wk/yr

Continue

Water polo, Founder & captain: water polo.

Founded club water polo team. Lead practice on weekends and organize monthly scrimmages.

This shows that the student places a great deal of importance on contributing to their home life.

Family Responsibilities

9, 10, 11, 12

Year

10 hr/wk, 52 wk/yr

Babysitter.

Care for younger siblings in the evenings when parents are working, including cooking dinner and helping them with their homework.

Journalism/Publication

11, 12

Year

5 hr/wk, 52 wk/yr

Continue

Founder of fitness blog "Sweat Stain."

Created blog reviewing athletic wear/fitness and workout routines. Post weekly and have generated 1,000 subscribers.

A clear description helps us understand the work on the blog.

School Spirit

9, 10, 11, 12

School

2 hr/wk, 30 wk/yr

Class representative. Chair of Jr Prom Committee.

Participate in weekly meetings to plan social events and fundraisers. Led planning for Junior Prom and Relay for Life.

This is much more evocative than the previous description!

Community Service (Volunteer)

11, 12

School

1 hr/wk, 20 wk/yr

Continue

Tutor & role model.

Run 1-hour after school homework group for five 3rd graders, focusing on math, science, and social skills.

Work (Paid)

11

Break

10 hr/wk, 4 wk/yr

Continue

Lab tech at Polytech U.

Intern in cancer research lab. Assisted grad students with experiments and learned how a lab functions.

This adds much more context to this activity: it is included because it is an important part of this student's athletic journey, but it explains how the student's priorities changed.

Athletics: JV/Varsity

9

School

8 hr/wk, 10 wk/yr

Track and field, Member of track team.

Ran 100m dash and 800m relay. Was unable to continue in 10th grade due to Water Polo commitments.

The detail here shows that the student took initiative to create and run this group.

Even though this is an independent activity, putting it in a category shows that the student is taking it seriously.

While "Government" sounds fancier, "School Spirit" might capture this better.

Listing this down lower is appropriate given the time commitment; be sure not to overblow things to make yourself look "better"!

Notice that jet skiing and Thanksgiving volunteering didn't make the cut: this keeps the admission officer's attention focused on what is most important to the student—even if it means leaving a few lines blank!